

# An Invitation to Step Off the Glass Floor

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There is a certain exciting poetic irony in reading *Meet the Savarnas: Indian Millennials Whose Mediocrity Broke Everything* by Ravikant Kisana while sitting in the over-curated, fresh and clean, and air-conditioned quietude of a savarna-nominated and dominated library, the so-called elite Delhi School of Economics' Ratan Tata Library. As a PhD scholar investigating savarna epistemology—not in my doctoral research but for my personal interest—I found myself feeling both too close and too distant from the very subject that Kisana tries to nudge into caste-awareness: the modern, urban, post-liberalisation Indian society, the so-called upper caste, “the savarna.”

Kisana's book is not exactly academic, like his profession, nor is it classically “popular” non-fiction about elite societies like *The Power Elite* or *The Affluent Society* or other similar texts. But it can be, depending on his savarna and non-savarna

**Meet the Savarnas: Indian Millennials Whose Mediocrity Broke Everything** by Ravikant Kisana, New Delhi: Ebury Press, 2025; pp 256, ₹699.

audience. It falls somewhere in between, a crisp, digestible, extended descriptive, and demonstrative monologue that flows like a podcast transcript shaped into eight readable chapters over 187 pages. Actually, this is not an academic critique and Kisana never claims this. In fact, this format allows for something the academy often forgets: accessibility and familiarity. Kisana speaks plainly, sometimes too plainly, to draw attention not just to the elephant in the room, but to the walls, ceilings, and privileges that keep the room intact. I mean not just caste, but how the very micro- and macro-level privileges and prejudices are linked to caste(s) in Indian society (or societies), both above and below the ceiling, as the book cover shows explicitly.

Kisana starts by revisiting the term “savarna” beyond just an ascriptive caste (in modern usage), tracing the elite exodus of the post-1990s millennials to the contemporary Gen z. The book reads like a guided storytelling session in small packets of writing. If you are expecting citations, references, footnotes, or jargon, you will be disappointed or relieved, depending on your expectations. With about 40 clickable links from news and social media sources, including some noticeable book references like William Dalrymple, Kancha Ilaiah, Sharmila Rege, Frantz Fanon, and a few others, the book consciously steps away from academic performance and towards cultural witnessing. And that is where it unsettles the reader most, especially academics from savarna backgrounds.

What is interesting is to read Kisana's audacity in describing what many refuse to name. He does not take refuge in the false innocence of neutrality, as one is supposed to do in academia. The stories and anecdotes drawn from his “everyday empiricism” are brutally familiar if you have ever sat in a classroom, newsroom, open mic poetry night, comedy show, or corporate pitch meeting dominated by self-assured, progressive, upwardly mobile savarnas. In Bourdieusian

terms, “field and space,” though Kisana does not refer to them explicitly. He names savarnas without naming them. They float through the chapters as exemplars of a caste that has long believed itself to be casteless. For instance, the Kulkarnis, Desais, Deshpandes, Chatterjees, Banerjees, Iyers, Iyengars, Mishras, Joshis, Tripathis, Dixits, and Dubes from all over India (p 3).

### Defining Savarna

Chapter 1, titled “What Is a Savarna?” starts with a story of a savarna Kulkarni woman, about how she is curious to know what the author (Kisana) is writing about. And then it comes: the introduction to the intellectual sphere, the culture of words, books, libraries, readings, interaction, discussion, and debate, which exposes the rich kind of intellectual habitus the *dwija* (twice-born) urban elite savarna possesses, and simultaneously, the insane *doxa* they carry about others. The question she raised to her friend (what is Kisana writing on?) is to check whether he is worthy enough to write, whether he has the same culture of knowledge production she was socialised into. And it tells of the heterogeneous culture between a *dwija* and a non-*dwija* savarna, as the author himself is from a non-*dwija* savarna background. Further, to give a clearer picture of what constitutes a “savarna,” the author provides two different definitions (p 10): (i) the traditional, which includes only varna categories (Brahmins, Kshatriyas, Vaishyas, and Shudras). (ii) A more accurate varna representation called the “jati system,” which further divides a social group—those who “have” or are “in possession of”—as savarna. That includes all traditional varna categories, further classified into *dwija* and non-*dwija* savarna; for instance, today’s non-reserved, the economically weaker sections (EWS), and Other Backward Classes (OBCs) of Hindu society.

To convert varna to savarna, it adds the avarna category, a group of people who possess nothing, the have-nots—constituting the untouchables and tribals, meaning today’s Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, and Nomadic Tribes. The author discusses how this social

system made slavery and servitude hereditary and linked it to spiritual salvation (p 11). He then briefly discusses Buddha, Kabir, Nanak, Mardana, B R Ambedkar, Kanshiram, and Mayawati, who challenged or are challenging the caste system. By the chapter’s end, he says: “I hope I can repay my debt to the Savarna by introducing them to themselves” (p 15). It means the author wants his audience to be from savarna backgrounds so they can know themselves and how he portrays them.

### Glass Ceilings and Floors

In Chapter 2, Kisana’s central metaphor, the glass floor (the book cover gives an idea), is an inversion of the more commonly feminist-invoked concept of the glass ceiling. This concept creates an invisible boundary separating the twofold division of savarna and avarna, that is, above and below the floor. It seems the author tries to explain the concept of graded inequality in vertically stacked compartments. This conceptualisation can be seen as an advanced version of the glass ceiling for collective/group applications, but the author fails or forgets to acknowledge its roots in the deeper graded hierarchies proposed by Ambedkar, not just in epistemological couples of above and below the floor, but many graded floors.

Speaking of above, that is, of the savarna, the floor itself is cushioned. It is a site of privilege production. It is the space where savarna habitus and all forms of capital are nurtured. It is a sword and shield. It is where savarna mediocrity is protected, where failure does not mean a fall, and where structures of family capital, cultural literacy, and English fluency ensure that even rebellion and conservatism are branded, aesthetic, and monetisable. The “start-up kids,” the “new media collectives,” the “liberal arts warriors,” the “solitary success,” the “commutative reach of poor Savarnas” (pp 24–25), all emerge as case studies in what Kisana calls performative actions. They critique the system, but from the comfort of drawing rooms with good lighting and better wifi: not to change, but to show.

For those below, the author highlights how they live like insects, citing series

like *Paatal Lok* and *Reptiles of Kurla* (pp 30–31). For them, the space above the floor carries collective hate, disregard, and cumulative prejudice. Savarnas from above see those below as insects, living lives of brute violence, deprivation, deep immorality, and as sources of dread and fear.

The next chapter, titled after a Reliance Mobile advertisement from the early 2000s by cricketer V Sehwag—“Karlo Duniya Mutthi Mein: Corporate Savarna–Capital Complex”—is fascinating. The author draws connections from that advertisement to the contemporary debate on the “70-hour work culture” initiated by savarna capitalist Narayan Murthy and supported by many others. He discusses Murthy’s familial nexus inside and outside India in brief, and by citing the National Stock Exchange of India, shows how the material economy of this vast subcontinent is monopolised and hegemonised by tycoons from the Vaishya/Bania caste, such as Ambani, Adani, Mittal, Ruia, Jindal, Agarwal, Goenka, and Birla (p 41)—while the Brahmin–Kayastha, that is, the *bhadralok*, dominate intellectual institutions like universities (p 44). Furthermore, he discusses the Master of Business Administration (MBA)–Common Admission Test (CAT) coaching market, colleges, and the elite exodus from it—how MBA pedagogy made Bania/Vaishya capitalists believe they are India’s supermen, destined to transform her through their start-ups and businesses, and eventually how they failed to do that.

Chapter 4—Student of the Year—gives a brief yet bird’s-eye view of politics and academia, especially from savarna political parties (Bharatiya Janata Party, Aam Aadmi Party, Congress, etc) and their polarisation politics, their reservation

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politics, and weaponisation of education (especially English) from kindergarten to international schools and universities. The question of merit, the illusion of pedagogical superiority—this chapter is the best example of how savarnas accept modernity but never abandon their enslaving traditions in politics and academia. For example, the *guru-shishya parampara* on the one hand, and highly emphasised English education on the other. It gives the idea that the savarnas carry Western rationality while preserving and propagating conventional irrationality.

### From Homecoming to Exodus

Then, Chapters 5 and 6 linger around love, sex, romance and marriage, respectively. Both chapters shed light on how even desire and intimacy are deeply caste-coded in the consciousness of savarnas, under the sections of the savarna man and non-savarna woman, and the savarna woman and the non-savarna man. And how marriages, break-ups, Tinder bios, and heartbreak poetry all remain surprisingly endogamous. Here, Kisana does not moralise marriage, love, or intimacy, but he does point out the conspicuous patterns in having them, online and offline. Love, after all, is one of the last bastions of caste assertion, masked under the language of “vibe,” “values,” or “background.”

Lastly, Chapters 7 and 8—“Savarna Spiritual Gharwapasi from the ‘Development’ Valhalla” and “Leaving India Behind: The Savarna Exodus”—are quite contradictory and complementary to each other. They expose how savarnas accept and appropriate India’s so-called Hindu civilisational past through pseudo-historicised films, patriotic narratives, and patriarchal archetypes. It discusses how the elite savarna cohort that once mocked “superstitious traditions” as backward is now downloading Vaastu Shastra apps and passionately discussing the physics of the Ram Setu bridge (p 132). It shows there are contradictions and hypocrisies in their collective beliefs, thoughts, and actions.

Then the author discusses how the same savarna cohort that positioned

itself as the Sherpa guide to making India a superpower by 2047 now appears to be running away from the very Indian society it was meant to transform, becoming hyper-visible minorities in Canada, the US, the UK, Germany, Australia, and New Zealand. In the final sections, the author critically exposes his favourite and most hated generation—Gen Z—from their birth to adolescence to their performativity. He shows how this generation grew between two savarna cultural systems: (i) being pulled towards Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s vision, and (ii) positioning itself as deeply critical. They learnt both languages but commit to neither. He argues that these elite savarna Gen Zs, more than anyone else, understand that in a caste society, identity is performance and cosplay (pp 169–70). Therefore, he predicts these Gen Zs will leave India soon, and ultimately, the country’s future by default will fall into the hands of those below the glass floor, and that is what “Viksit Bharat @2047” will look like.

### In Conclusion

What makes the book especially relevant at this moment is that, where academic texts often circle around definitions, debates, and detours, Kisana opts for narrative, humour, sarcasm, and even exasperation. This is not the sociological imagination à la C Wright Mills but Ambedkar’s reasoned rage delivered through pop culture analogies. There is a pedagogy here, but it is un-disciplinary, emotionally literate, and aware of its limits. One might call it critical-savarna pedagogy because it neither flatters caste innocence nor rewards savarna guilt with absolution.

Perhaps what I loved most was the way Kisana makes the reader feel watched. For those of us who have studied in liberal elite spaces, been on panels, fellowships, artist residencies, open mics, or WhatsApp groups, where “inclusivity” was a buzzword but never a practice, as he mentioned, the book feels like someone finally turning on the lights. There is no escape. Even self-reflexivity will not save you. And yet, this is not a bitter book. It is simply tired of the charades.

For readers coming from an anti-caste or Bahujan discourse, much of this may feel like old news dressed in new prose. But therein lies its utility. If caste operates through silence and comfort, then calling out its avatars in media, academia, literature, and even sex is a radical act. If nothing else, *Meet the Savarnas* gives us a language of naming the unnamed, explaining the implicit, and unsettling the unmarked.

As a scholar-in-the-making, I did find myself wanting it to be more structured, with more conceptual tightness. But perhaps that is not the book’s project, as it is an author’s testimony and not a thesis. As someone studying the architecture of savarna knowledge production, I found Kisana’s work to be less a destination and more a provocation. It is not the final word on caste privilege. It is the kind of book that makes you want to write your own.

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